> As for your own business also, you need not be anxious. After I purchase the steamers, I will turn my mind towards your business & will do it successfully & profitably. God wants to test us & we must wait & undergo all his trials. Then He will grant us everything we want.[44]

Unfortunately, it appears that there were some traders in Tuticorin who were working at cross purposes. VOC's letter to a Tuticorin merchant—combining faith in god with anger against Swadeshi's foes—gives us a window into his mind at that time.

> Have you got rid of your wretched partner? Did you meet the S.K. who was preaching publicly that the man who has born to … would ship by the B.I.S.N. Co. boats. Some days back I wrote a letter to him from here. Go to him, draw everything from his mouth regarding the Swadeshi Steamer … & then write to me.[45]

The addressee of the letter and its context are missing. But these were testing times, with the rivals of SSNCo out to sabotage the purchase of the steamers. VOC was fulminating and not beyond using an abusive word or two.

It was another month before there was any real progress on this front. On Christmas Eve 1906, *Swadesamitran* reported that it had received a wire from VOC that he had bought a ship and that more news would be forthcoming the next day.[46] The promised epistle has not been traced, but details of a later letter by VOC to *Swadesamitran*, written towards the end of January 1907, were reproduced in *India*:[47]

> We had earlier written to the Swadeshi press that our SSNCo has purchased a steamer on 22 December and that the steamer would reach the shores of Tuticorin in the current month of January. However, the proprietor of the steamer, intending to refurbish her before delivering her, had sent the steamer to the dockyards. Consequently, the steamer did not leave Europe at the earlier date. We have now received telegrams and letters that the repairs have been completed and that she will leave Europe on 4 February; sailing at a speed of 12 half miles for every hour and a half, she would reach Bombay before the end of the month.

There was news of the second steamer as well. 'The steamer bought on 24 January and two other steam launches to be purchased over the next few